

How to rank in Google AI Overviews: the local-service version

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How to rank in Google AI Overviews: the local-service version

By Dillon Mohr, Momentum Digital, Philadelphia

You don't rank in a Google AI Overview. You get cited by one. Google writes the overview from pages it already trusts and links a few as sources. For a local service business, the pages that get cited are specific procedures and clear service pages, not homepages. Make sure Google can read your site, fix one page, then measure monthly.

Everything below is the version for one trade, one town, one page at a time.

Why don't the existing guides help a local business?

Because they weren't written for you.

"How to rank in AI overviews" gets about 260 searches per month in the US. It peaked at 1,300 in September 2025 and settled. The results are an AI-tracking startup, SE Ranking, Google's own page on succeeding in AI search, then Semrush, Ahrefs and Search Engine Land. Every one is written for a marketer with a tool subscription and a hundred pages to optimize.

Google's own page is the one worth reading. The rest assume you have a content team. You have a truck and a phone. So here's what the same advice looks like at that scale.

Which page types get cited?

I'll use our own site as the example because I can see the data.

In a sampled window of AI Overview answers from August 2025 to August 2026, needmomentum.com was cited 81 times. The pages that earned those citations:

- A how-to on verifying a Google Business Profile with the postcard, cited next to five Google support pages and two YouTube videos.
- Our Google Ads management page, cited for a "near me" style question.
- A DIY web design page, cited alongside YouTube and a couple of software review sites.

Notice what they have in common. Each one answers a single question completely. Each has been up for years. None is a homepage. None says "we're the best". They explain how to do a thing.

The category-level data says the same. Across AI Overview answers about answer engine optimization, the top sources are YouTube, Reddit and Google's own developer docs. Video walkthroughs, people answering each other, and reference material. That's what gets cited. Write the reference material for your trade.

What blocks a page from being cited at all?

Before any of this works, Google has to be able to read your site. That sounds obvious. It isn't.

We ran a baseline for a Pittsburgh painting company in late August 2026 and found that the hosting company's bot protection was blocking the www version of the site, the sitemap and the WordPress API for anything that wasn't a Google IP. The robots file had a truncated rule. The homepage carried product schema on a painting site. One FAQ answer had been pasted in from a different question. A town name was misspelled.

None of that is "AI optimization". It's a site a machine can't read cleanly. Fix reading first. The checklist:

1. Can a non-Google crawler load your homepage, your sitemap and one service page? Test it from a tool, not your own browser.
2. Does your robots file say what you think it says?
3. Is the schema on each page the right type for what the page is?
4. Does every FAQ answer actually answer its question?
5. Are your town names spelled right?

Boring. Also the difference between citable and invisible.

What is the one page to fix first?

The service page for the job you want most. Not the homepage. One job, one page.

Build it like this:

- **Heading:** the job plus the area. "Heat pump installation in Delaware County."
- **First paragraph:** a direct answer in 40 to 60 words. What it is, who it's for, what it costs if you'll stand behind a range, how long it takes.
- **Section headings in question form.** Pull them from your phone log. "Does a heat pump work in a Pennsylvania winter?" "Do I need a permit?" Under each, a plain answer first, detail second.

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- **Where you serve.** Towns, not "the tri-state area".
 - **Three to five FAQs** at the bottom, one or two sentences each.
 - **An author with a name, and a date.** Machines and people both want to know who said this and when.
 - **FAQ schema** if your site can do it without a plugin fight.

For a multi-city events company we rebuilt ten landing pages this way in August 2026: one heading, nine sections, five FAQs each, FAQ and breadcrumb schema, every page checked on desktop and mobile before publish. The internal readiness score averaged 92 out of 100. The evidence file for that work ends with a line I'd put on every report: that number "is an internal launch readiness score. It is not a Google ranking, an AIOSEO score, or a ranking guarantee." Scores are not ranks. Neither are AI visibility scores. Which brings me to measurement.

How do I measure it without a rank?

"AI overviews tracker" gets about 720 searches per month in the US. People want a tool. You don't need one yet.

A spreadsheet with four columns: engine, exact prompt, date, sources cited. Ask your 20 buyer questions in Google with AI Overviews on. Log every answer. Re-run monthly with the same questions. Report cited or not cited, per question, per month.

That's it. It's not a rank. It's a dated observation you can repeat. If an agency shows you a "visibility score", ask what it's made of and whether they can show you the prompts. If they can't, it's a feeling with a number on it.

FAQ

Do I need schema markup to appear in AI Overviews? It helps machines read structure, but it doesn't earn a citation on its own. A crawlable page that answers a specific question comes first. Schema is the label on the box, not the contents.

Does my homepage count? Rarely. Cited pages answer one question. Homepages introduce a company. Build the specific page and let the homepage do its own job.

How long does it take? I don't have a number I'd publish. Date the baseline, fix one page, re-measure in 30 days, and compare. That's the only honest timeline.

The next step

If you'd like someone to check whether your site can be read and which page to fix first, I'll do a 15-minute snapshot: three observations with the evidence for each, and one suggested next step. Free. No deck, no pitch. Reach me through needmomentum.com with your top service and your city.